Symbols of the Holocaust

(A Poetry Compilation)

By Jesse Parent

First They Came by Pastor Martin Niemooler

First they came for the Communists
And I did not speak out
Because I was not a Communist
Then they came for the Socialists
And I did not speak out
Because I was not a Socialist
Then they came for the trade unionists
And I did not speak out
Because I was not a trade unionist
Then they came for the Jews
And I did not speak out
Because I was not a Jew
Then they came for me
And there was no one left
To speak out for me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Pastor Martin Niemooler
Book: Then They Came For Me
ISBN: 978-0465097869
Publisher: Basic Books
Date (Month/Year): Sept 18, 2018

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INTRODUCTION

Today I, (insert name) speak out . . . Symbols make up a significant part of any cultural fabric. They have the power to transform a concept into a reality, to speak without words and to effect emotional responses from each and every one of us.

Symbols of the Holocaust – A Poetry Compilation by Pastor Martin Neimooler, Jesse Parent, Jennifer Roy and Elie Weisel.

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Hooked Cross by Jesse Parent

Little brother,
look what they've done to me.

For millennia
I have woven myself into humanity's dreams,
raced comet-like across their collective consciousness.
As basic as a circle,
a hooked cross.
A child of lines
and busy hands.
Simple. Recognizable.
They called me Swastika.

I was everywhere.
Even in the one place I wished I wasn't.

I admit I was jealous of you, little brother
and the star you rose up on.
For I was just a hooked cross,
glossed over on cracked claypots,
and deerskin teepees,
hidden along with kisses on the collars
of Chinese children
ironically, to protect them from evil spirits.
All of Asia blended me into their backgrounds,
Jainism, Buddhism, Hinduism.
I could tell you where any temple was.
A sun symbol.
A heart's seal.
Eternity.
A minor celebrity on one continent,
a child's absent doodle on the rest.

He took me West, little brother,
told me to point right and lean,
hold the pose.
Shone a bright, white spotlight on me
while I danced on a red carpet.
They all waved at me, little brother.
I got caught up in the rush
To become a major celebrity.

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It was too late to turn back
They slaughtered each other
under my hooked shadow,
the smoke of their flesh darkening my form.
I let them make me into something horrible,
simple, recognizable, detestable.

Humanity's dreams no longer idly trace my form
in innocent doodles.
Countless millennia may never wash away
the stench on my lines
no matter which way I turn.
A minor celebrity on one continent,
a symbol of hatred on the rest.
So many killed while I waved over them,
their murderers justifying themselves
by the meaning they put into my shape.
They killed for me.

You don't have my hooks, little brother,
but we have the same parents,
the same simplicity of lines.
We have had different men who have defined us,
even if we have both been worn by popes.
My body count is well over 6 million, little brother.

Pray they do not start counting up the ones
that were killed for you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jesse Parent
Book: To the Baby in My Belly (You Were Delicious)
ISBN: e-book
Publisher: Jesse Parent
Date (Month/Year): 2010
Can be purchased on-line at
http://www.jesster.net/store.html

TRANSITION

The Swastika wasn't the only symbol of the Holocaust. The Star of David is a symbol we all know -- two overlaid equilateral triangles forming a six-pointed star.

Yellow Star (excerpt) by Jennifer Roy

(Pg 3-8) Fall 1939
I, [Sylvia Perlmutter], am four and a half years old,
going on five,
Hiding in my special place behind the armchair in
the parlor,
Listening.

The worry of grown-ups fills the air,
"Must we go, Isaac?" Mother says to my father.

"We must leave right away," Papa says. "This city is
unsafe for Jews."
My mind freezes
On one word –
Jews.
Jews.
We are Jews.

I am Jewish, but that is all I know.
What does it matter that we are Jews?
It is wartime.
We are Jews.
The Nazis closed down
a small section of the city.
They said it is swarming
with infectious disease,
but still,
they ordered all Jews
to leave their homes
immediately
and move into that space.
It is called a ghetto.
All the Jews?
That must be more than one hundred!
(One hundred is the largest number I know.)

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Papa corrects me.
"Over one hundred thousand people,
maybe twice that."

Orange
is the color of my coat
with matching muffler
that I got as a present
before the war.

Yellow
is the color of
the felt six-pointed star
that is sewn onto my coat.
It is the law
that all Jews have to wear the
Star of David
when they leave their house,
or else be arrested.

I wish I could
rip the star off
(carefully, stitch by stitch, so as not to ruin my lovely
coat),
because yellow is meant to be

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a happy color,
Not the color of hate.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jennifer Roy
ISBN: 978-0761463108
Publisher: Two Lions
Date (Month/Year): June 2014

TRANSITION

In 1939 the Germans invaded Poland. Two hundred and seventy thousand people were isolated in the Lodz ghetto. In 1945 the ghetto was liberated. Only 800 walked out of the ghetto. Of those who survived only twelve were children. Sylvia Perlmutter was one of them.

In the words of George Santayana, "Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it." The world must never forget what the Jewish people endured.

Never Shall I Forget Elie Weisel

Never shall I forget that night, the first night in camp, that turned my life into one long night seven times sealed.

Never shall I forget that smoke.

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Never shall I forget the small faces of the children whose bodies I saw transformed into smoke under a silent sky.

Never shall I forget those flames that consumed my faith for ever.

Never shall I forget the nocturnal silence that deprived me for all eternity of the desire to live.

Never shall I forget those moments that murdered my God and my soul and turned my dreams to ashes.

Never shall I forget those things, even were I condemned to live as long as God Himself.

(From the opening poem)

They came for the Jews
And I did not speak out
Because I was not a Jew

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Elie Wiesel
Book: Night (Pg 106)
ISBN: 978-0374500016
Publisher: Hill and Wang
Date (Month/Year): January 2006

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CLOSING

Swastikas . . . Yellow Stars . . . . Ghettos . . . . Concentration camps . . . . Smoke under a silent sky. . . Never should WE forget.

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